

Uber nearing autonomous cars without human backup driver

Uber plans to carry passengers in autonomous vehicles without human backup drivers in about the same time frame as competitors, that is, sometime next year.

Waymo, autonomous car unit of Alphabet Inc.'s Google, is currently testing on public roads in the Phoenix area without human backups and plans to carry passengers soon. General Motors Co.'s Cruise Automation has promised to start sometime next year in an unspecified location.

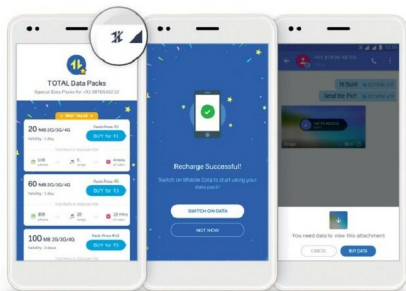
Volvo XC-90 SUVs are being prepared for the work. Uber Technologies has 215 test vehicles carrying passengers with human backups in Phoenix, San Francisco, Pittsburgh and Toronto. These travel 128,747km (80,000 miles) per week gathering data and have given 50,000 paid rides.

San Francisco-based Uber started carrying passengers with autonomous vehicles in 2016, first with two Uber employees on board. The person in the passenger seat documented the vehicle's behaviour, while the one on the driver's side would intervene if the car needed help. The vehicles have improved to the point where Uber has removed one of the humans and now the backup driver enters data on a screen in rare cases.

Uber would gradually expand the size of the area as mapping is done and vehicles become more capable. Currently, the cars are limited to 64kmph (40 miles per hour).

The Indian messaging app Total runs without a data connection

Hike, the Indian messaging app valued at more than \$1 billion, is taking a unique approach to battling WhatsApp, which involves dismantling its service, layering it on budget Android phones and offering free connectivity.



Unlike WhatsApp Hike's messaging app Total runs without data connection

The company, which is backed by Tencent and Foxconn, has unveiled 'Total, built by Hike' service aimed at reaching novice smartphone owners and first-time Internet users in India.

With Total, Hike is offering a different kind of experience to reach new Internet users before WhatsApp gets them. The most notable part of Total is that it runs without a data connection.

Total is Hike's effort to make things easier. The start-up teamed up with mobile carriers and OEMs for Total, with device makers bundling a tweaked version of Android that makes Hike the default text/call app and loads features like Hike's wallet, cricket news and horoscopes. The registration process is now down to under five steps, too.

Owners of Total-powered devices can get online without a data plan, thanks to an adaptation of USSD technology that is typically used to send basic information to devices like balance checking. Hike has developed a proprietary system that, with approval from carriers, allows USSD to be used for basic Internet access. Supplied for free, it allows a range of Hike services to operate on a device when it is offline.

Security flaws in chips put virtually all phones and computers at risk

Security researchers have disclosed a set of security flaws that could let hackers steal sensitive information from nearly every modern computing device containing chips from Intel, Advanced Micro Devices and ARM Holdings. One of the bugs is specific to Intel but another affects laptops, desktop computers, smartphones, tablets and Internet servers alike. Intel and ARM insisted that the issue was not a design flaw, but it will require users to download a patch and update their operating system to fix.

Researchers with Alphabet Inc.'s Google Project Zero, in conjunction with academic and industry researchers from several countries, discovered two flaws. The first, called Meltdown, affects Intel chips and lets hackers bypass the hardware barrier between applications run by users and the computer's memory, potentially letting hackers read a computer's memory and steal passwords. The second, called Spectre, affects chips from Intel, AMD and ARM, and lets hackers potentially trick otherwise error-free applications into giving up secret information.

The researchers said Apple and Microsoft had patches ready for users of desktop computers affected by Meltdown. Daniel Gruss, one of the researchers at Graz University of Technology who discovered Meltdown, called it "probably one of the worst CPU bugs ever found" in an interview with Reuters.